the province of Illyricum (the name was later used also for Napoleon's occupied territories in the region) roughly where Bosnia and Herzegovina is today. This delimitation, with slight changes, continued to mark political divisions – albeit by new and different polities – right up until World War I. It also features prominently in Samuel Huntington's acclaimed work on the clash of civilisations.[4]

Diocletian's aim was certainly not to create Eastern Europe – he did not think of East and West in those terms, nor, of course, did he think of Europe. He decided to divide the great empire to improve its management and above all its protection against various barbarians, mostly Germanic tribes and peoples – in other words (ironically) future Europeans. Yet his choice of the division line was not purely arbitrary: he drew it where Latin influence faded and gave way to predominantly Greek influence. (The delimitation line was a couple of hundred miles east of *Castra ad Fluvium Frigidus*, the Roman outpost near modern Vrhpolje, the Slovenian village mentioned above.) The division only concerned Mediterranean Europe; the vast areas north of it, where today lie other regions that are part of Eastern Europe, were not included in this mapping, as they were out of Roman military control. As we shall see, the Greek half would later play a very important role in the formation of Eastern Europe.

In the times with which we are concerned at this point, Europe as a political entity did not yet exist but the Roman and Greek worlds – as the spiritual foundations of Europe – did. In fact, with the demise of the Western Roman Empire, it was the Byzantine Empire which took over the role of 'Europe' of the time. With Constantine, the capital of the Roman Empire was formally moved to the East. From then on, it was Byzantium, which regarded itself as the true Rome, as the 'world superpower', as 'Europe', and, as such, it continued to intervene militarily not only in the Apennine Peninsula (one of the most splendid achievements of Byzantine art can be found in Ravenna, an Italian city just south of Venice) and the Mediterranean, but also as far as the Iberian peninsula. And the power of Byzantium began to gain additional momentum once the pagan West had been subdued by barbarians. The city, known also as Constantinople, was at the heart of a Christian empire and it continued to flourish.

There have been ongoing attempts to define what made – or makes – Europe and its peoples European. The answer to this question proves not